Infant Attention Is a Family of Processes, Not a Trait

Attention in infancy comprises dissociable functions (alertness, orienting, feature attention, endogenous control) that change on different schedules; inattention in a given hour is not a character verdict.

GRADE: MODERATE-FUNCTIONS; LOW-TRAIT | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: COGNITION | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Infants do not process every available signal equally. Attention selects. Colombo (2001) treats infant visual attention as several functions—alertness, spatial orienting, attention to object features, and endogenous/voluntary control—that are present in rudimentary form early and then change on dissociable postnatal schedules.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Colombo (2001), Annual Review of Psychology, is a research synthesis of looking, habituation, and related work, not an RCT of "attention training." The review's claim is mechanistic and taxonomic: different attentional systems mature at different rates, so the role of attention in development is an interaction among systems at different levels of maturity. Everyday causal effects of changing attention on later learning are harder to isolate than laboratory associations.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

No portable effect size for "better attention" as a developmental intervention. Look duration and habituation rate have been used as individual-difference measures; they are not destiny.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (attentional function review, not an observational population phenotype association).

Arousal, hunger, fatigue, distress, overstimulation, and posture alter looking. Parent-report "inattentive" and laboratory look duration are not the same construct. Prediction from early looking to later scores is not determination.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean a tired or distressed infant lacks capacity. Does not mean more stimulation produces more attention. Does not mean attention is a parenting score.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary conditions in which an infant can settle, look, and disengage are consistent with the finding. Attention-training products and performance dashboards are not justified here.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Colombo (2001), Annual Review of Psychology (DOI 10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.337)